

CHAPTER 10 OF 13 • PART FOUR

The Security Kit

Assume the boundary is already crossed. Least privilege is measured by what one stolen credential can reach.



Thirteen chapters, gathered into six movements.

01 A Tuesday — one engineer, wake to sleep

02 The words — naming what you just watched

03 Protagonist and antagonist — where a design starts

04 Solution types — which answer is wanted

→ **Six kits — data, compute, network, scale, reliability, security**

06 Two designs, then the map back — Instagram, a parking app, and what you keep

WHERE THIS SITS

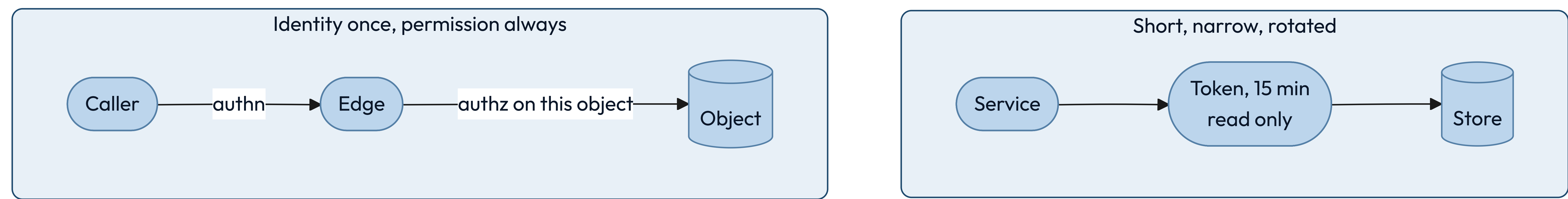
Chapter nine asked whether the copies fail apart. Ask it about keys.

Redundancy only helps when failures are independent, and the same question about credentials is this chapter: what one stolen key can reach. It assumes the boundary from chapter two and the dependency and quota practices from the kits before it. Six questions find the holes before somebody else does, and the chapter closes the shelf with a full discover-then-design pass on a registration spike.

SECURITY

Assume the boundary
is already crossed.

Two of the four defenses limit what a caller may do once it is already inside.

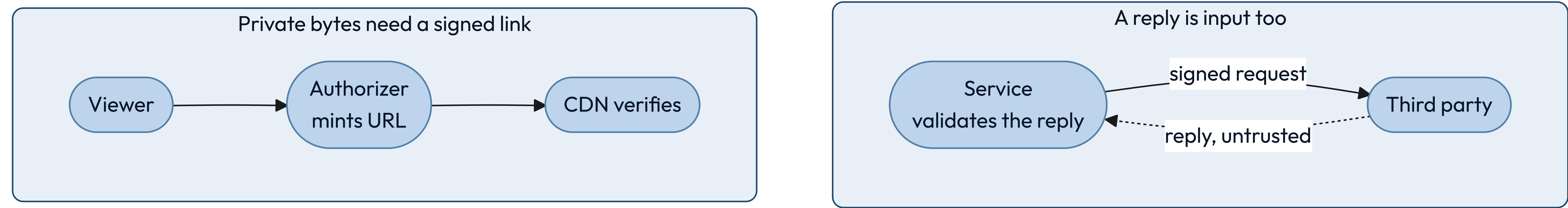


KEY INSIGHT

Neither one asks whether the caller is honest. Both are written as if the caller is lying.

★ The reliability kit asked whether your copies fail apart. This kit asks the same question about credentials: when one is stolen, does the damage stop somewhere, or does it reach everything the service can reach? A blast radius is a blast radius, whether the cause is a dead zone or a leaked token.

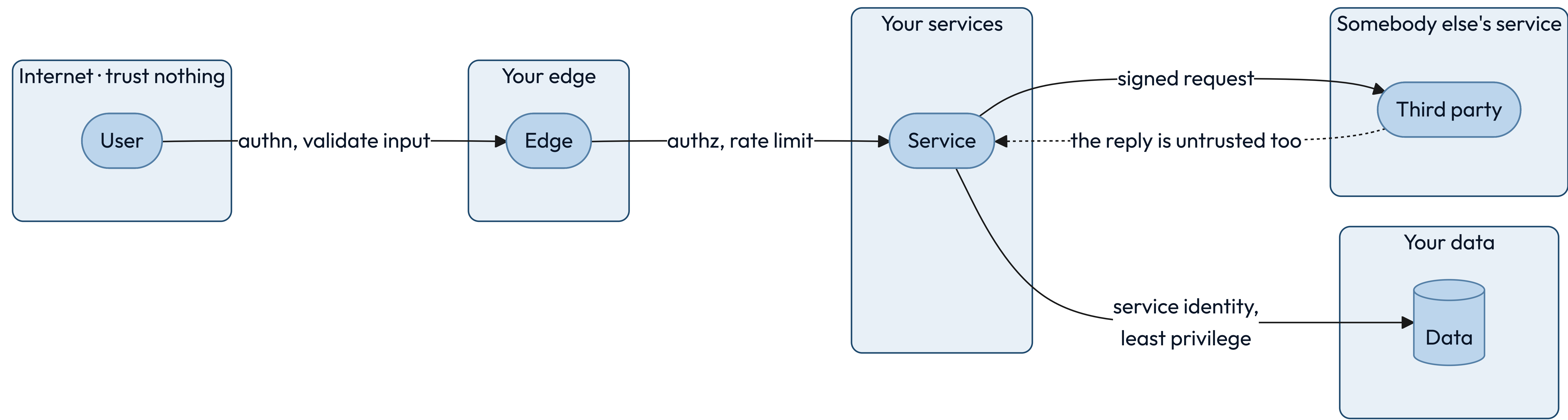
The last two cover both directions in which data leaves your control.



KEY INSIGHT

Sign what leaves, distrust what comes back: neither runs on a machine you own.

Every arrow that crosses a trust boundary needs a check on the far side.



KEY INSIGHT

The check belongs on the far side of the line, never the near side.

Authentication asks who you are. Authorization asks what you may touch.

AUTHENTICATION

Establishes identity once, at the edge, and hands down a claim anyone downstream can verify. Getting it wrong lets the wrong person in.



AUTHORIZATION

Decides, on every single request, whether this identity may touch this specific object. Getting it wrong lets the right person read somebody else's data.

Least privilege is measured by what one stolen credential can reach.

Assume any single credential eventually leaks. The design question is not whether that happens; it is how far the person holding it can travel, and for how long.

THE CHECK

You can say in one sentence what each service account could reach if stolen.

SCOPE IT AND EXPIRE IT

Narrow permissions, short lifetimes and automatic rotation beat a careful human.

SEPARATE READ FROM WRITE

Most services need one or the other. Almost none needs to delete.

Encryption has three states, and a fourth thing that outranks all of them.

- 01 Transit** TLS everywhere, including between your own services. Networks are untrusted.
- 02 Rest** Disk and backup encryption. Stops a stolen device, not a stolen credential.
- 03 Use** Decrypted in memory to be processed. The hardest state, and the one attacked.
- 04 Keys** A managed store or an HSM, rotated on a schedule, never in the repository.

Six questions find the holes before somebody else does.

- ☐ Can someone pretend to be another identity? spoofing
- ☐ Can data be changed in transit or at rest? tampering
- ☐ Can an actor deny having done something? repudiation
- ☐ Can private data reach the wrong reader? disclosure
- ☐ Can one caller exhaust a shared resource? denial
- ☐ Can a caller gain rights nobody granted? elevation

Most of the code you ship, you did not write and have not read.

Maya's Tuesday stopped when a package registry went down. That same registry is also the shortest path into her build: whoever can publish a version she installs can run their code on her machine, and then inside her deploy.

Pin exact versions and commit the lock file, so the build you tested is the build that ships. Keep an inventory of what you actually depend on, including everything your dependencies pulled in behind you. Take updates on a schedule you chose rather than the moment they appear, and read the diff of anything that touches a credential, a network call, or a build step.

An authorized caller can still take the whole system down.

Reach for it when

Anything is shared: a database, a queue, a paid third party, an image decoder.

Walk away when

The caller is a trusted internal batch you would rather see fail loudly than throttled.

The constraint you inherit

A limit needs an identity to count against. Use the account, the key and the address.

Sign your name to a design only when you can say all five.

01

Every request is authorized against the specific object

Not the endpoint. Object-level checks are where the breaches happen.

02

Secrets never enter the repository or a log line

They live in a managed store, are injected at runtime, and they rotate.

03

All input is untrusted, including from your own services

A compromised internal caller is the ordinary case. Design for it.

04

Every privileged action is attributable

An immutable record of who, what, when, and from where.

05

Every dependency is pinned, inventoried and rate-limited

You did not write most of your code, and an authorized caller can still exhaust you.

YOUR TURN

Run those six questions on one arrow: the presigned upload URL.

A client asks your API for a URL, then writes bytes straight into your object store with it. Nobody on your side sees those bytes until they have landed.

Name three of the six that land on that one arrow, and the limit that stops each.
Then turn the page.

ONE ANSWER

Three of the six land on that arrow, and one grant answers all three.

- 01

Tampering

The client picks its own key and writes over somebody else's photo. The grant names the exact key.
-
- 02

Denial

One account fills your storage at your expense. The grant carries a size ceiling and a rate per account.
-
- 03

Elevation

Chosen bytes reach an image decoder that never expected them. The grant names one content type and expires in minutes.

YOUR TURN • DISCOVER

Registration opens at nine. Discover the system before you design any of it.

Twelve thousand students, every one of them refreshing at 08:59. Six thousand courses, most with a hard seat limit. A seat handed to two people is something a human has to unpick, by hand, with an apology.

Write four lines: the protagonist, the antagonist, one invariant that must never break, and the number that describes the antagonist. Then turn the page.

Four lines, and the last two decide the design.

```
Protagonist  A student at 08:59, one course short of a full timetable.  
Antagonist   Twelve thousand people arriving in the same second.  
Invariant    A seat is held by one student or by nobody. Never two.  
The number   ~12,000 requests in the first second, then near zero all term.
```

The invariant wants one writer and a transaction. The number wants everything spread wide. Those two pulling against each other is the design.

YOUR TURN • DESIGN

Now design it, on the same four lines.

You have the six kits and everything in them. Name the rung this is asking for, two entries you would reach for and what each one holds up, and one box you would take out on paper.

Do not draw an architecture. Four lines again, then turn the page.

The invariant picks the store. The spike picks what goes in front.

01	The rung	Scaled. The load is known and the invariant is not negotiable.
02	Relational, and the condition goes inside the write	Decrement <code>WHERE seats_left > 0</code> , then check how many rows changed. Read the count first and decide in your code, and two requests both see the last seat.
03	A bounded queue in front of it	Admitted in order, each told their place. The store never sees twelve thousand at once.
04	What you would remove	The queue, once registration closes. It earns its place one hour a year.

WHAT YOU NOW HOLD

Sixteen entries, six sets of invariants, and one thing worth admitting.

You will not reach for most of these. The bigger design ahead spends six of them, and the smaller one spends five. That is what a kit is: what you own, not what you use.

The entries are concepts, not products, so they outlast the names. What you carry out of here is the sentence you can now say when you did not reach for something.

CHAPTER 10 OF 13 • HOW TO THINK ABOUT SYSTEMS

The shelf is full.

*Sixteen entries and six sets of invariants.
Chapters eleven and twelve spend them — the
first designs a product at the top of the ladder,
the second starts at the bottom and climbs.*



Glossary

A – T

TERM	DEFINITION
API	The contract one system offers another: the operations and what they promise.
CDN	Caches near readers, so bytes travel a short distance instead of an ocean.
TLS	The encryption any connection crossing a network you do not own should have.